the Shan state. Nationalist leaders claim the Shan's make up approximately 50 percent of the overall population, while the junta claims the number is closer to one-third.

WOMEN

The status of women in Myanmar has been historically high. Legally, women enjoy rights comparable to men. Women are allowed to own property and can enter any profession. Women have equal inheritance rights with their male siblings and retain control over their dowries. In case of divorce, the wife is entitled to half of the family's assets. Divorce rates are very low in Myanmar. Educational status in Myanmar for women has been impressive. When the university system was fully functional, women made up over half of the college population. Women in Myanmar control most family affairs, and also have a significant role in economic decision making. Women have total access to professional careers such as those in medicine and education.

One of the main areas of contrast would be regarding religion. Particular areas in some of the Buddhists shrines are off limits to females. The birth of a woman is also considered less significant in regard to gaining merit. Over 40,000 women serve as nuns in Myanmar, but that is considered less significant than entering the monkhood. In order to reach the state of nirvana, women must first be reincarnated as males. Finally, the monopoly on power in society by the male-dominated military over the past four decades has helped to reinforce stereotypes of male superiority in Myanmar society.

LANGUAGE

Burmese (part of the Tibeto-Burman languages) is the official language of Myanmar. Burmese is spoken by approximately 80 percent of the population. As with the majority of languages in Southeast Asia, Burmese is a tonal language. Approximately 10 percent of the population speaks Tai languages such as Shan, Khun, and Tai Lu. The Mon of Lower Myanmar and the Palaung of the east speak a Mon-Khmer language. In total, the